NICK STERNIOTIS

Infrastructure & Cloud Platform Engineer | 20+ Years in IT | Linux | Virtualisation | Infrastructure Automation | Production Operations

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Work authorisation: EU citizen — no employment permit required
Availability: 1 month notice
Target: senior infrastructure / platform engineering, remote within Ireland and the EU

PROFILE

Infrastructure engineer with 20+ years in IT, most of it on the layer that has to stay up: Linux systems, hypervisor and container estates, the network paths between them, and the automation used to change any of it without breaking it. I have held incident ownership and change ownership on hosted production infrastructure, written the postmortem afterwards, and written the runbook that came out of it.

Configuration is version-controlled and reviewed, and the checks that guard it fail the build rather than printing a warning. Cloud architecture is my certified discipline on AWS (Certified Solutions Architect – Professional). Azure Cloud exposure is limited (approximately 2–3 months); Active Directory and Microsoft 365 administration sit separately, inside employed roles.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Linux & production operations: Debian/Ubuntu and RHEL-family administration; systemd, package and patch management, service hardening; `ss`/`ip`/`nstat`-driven diagnosis; log analysis and service-level troubleshooting. Incident triage, mitigation, root-cause follow-up, runbooks.

Virtualisation & hosted infrastructure: Virtuozzo / OpenVZ container hosting and VMware vSphere in production hosting, KVM underneath both; Proxmox VE on a self-directed estate.

Containers: Docker and Docker Compose in production hosting; container hardening practices (rootless daemon, capability drops, read-only filesystems, image pinning, internal-only networks).

Networking: TCP/IP, routing and policy routing, DNS and DHCP, VLAN concepts, site-to-site and client VPN, NAT, firewall zones, reverse proxy and TLS termination; wired and fibre troubleshooting.

Infrastructure automation & configuration management: Ansible — 5 roles, 7 playbooks, executable inventory, idempotent runs, pinned tooling, Git-reviewed changes. Bash and Python for operational automation. Declarative state kept in git with validation that has to pass.

CI/CD & validation: GitHub Actions and Forgejo Actions, authored not consumed — YAML linting, an`ansible-lint` escalation to hard-fail, inventory parsing, playbook syntax checks, secret-pattern scanning, and regression tests that fail if a known-bad configuration reappears.

Cloud & identity: AWS architecture (Certified Solutions Architect – Professional) — VPC and network design, IAM boundaries, hybrid connectivity, cost and failure-mode trade-offs. Azure Cloud: limited exposure, approximately 2–3 months. Active Directory and Microsoft 365 administration in employed roles.

Storage, data & backup: ZFS pools and Proxmox Backup Server on a self-directed estate; Veeam and enterprise backup platforms in employed roles; SQL Server operational support; PostgreSQL administration behind self-hosted services; restore rehearsal treated as the actual control.

Observability: Prometheus, Grafana and Alertmanager on self-directed infrastructure, with small rule sets and probe-based checks; alert design shaped by service objectives rather than dashboards.

Security in operations: SSH hardening, fail2ban with a never-ban-the-management-path rule, least-privilege access, secret scanning in CI, threat modelling and security-focused validation as reviewed documents.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Cloud Systems & Operations Engineer — Scaleforce | Ireland, remote | Aug 2025 – present | Contract
Continuation of the working relationship after relocation to Ireland, as external contractor. - Troubleshoot Linux hosts, containerised workloads, service dependencies, connectivity and availability issues; own incident

triage and mitigation. - Maintain operational procedures and technical notes so investigations are repeatable. - Work across infrastructure, networking and platform layers in a shift-covered service environment.

Cloud Lead Engineer / Architect — Scaleforce | Cyprus | Nov 2023 – Aug 2025 | Full-time - Supported Linux production infrastructure and hosted workloads across multiple data-centre environments, including Virtuozzo/OpenVZ container hosting. - Contributed to infrastructure and platform design decisions across compute, networking, integration and operational reliability. - Escalation point for complex hosting and infrastructure issues in a small-team operating model. - Investigated service issues spanning hosting, reverse-proxy layers, application processes and database dependencies.

Independent IT & Cloud Consultant — self-employed | Ireland, remote | Aug 2025 – present | Part-time - Domain and DNS configuration, VPS and Linux hosting with security applied at install time. - CDN, reverse-proxy and TLS termination configuration and troubleshooting.

IT Support / Operations Engineer — FXGlobe LTD | Cyprus, hybrid | Jul – Oct 2023 | Contract - Office and cloud-connected infrastructure support; network security configuration across local and overseas offices. - VoIP/softphone deployment across branches; connectivity and call-quality investigation. - Introduced a ticketing workflow and structured onboarding/offboarding with hardware provisioning and permission lifecycle.

IT Operations Engineer (field / on-site) — Simplex Cyprus | Cyprus | May 2022 – Jun 2023 | Full-time - Data-centre operations, VMware environments, hardware lifecycle and SQL Server operational support. - Endpoint, network and service resolution, with escalation of infrastructure-level incidents.

IT Field & Infrastructure Engineer / IT Operations Consultant — Konstantinos Kokkinos | Greece, remote | Mar 2005 – Dec 2009 and Apr 2012 – Apr 2022 - Field and remote support for business customers: servers, Windows and Linux systems, LAN/WAN connectivity. - Installation and troubleshooting of copper Ethernet and fibre infrastructure; end-to-end diagnosis. - Advised on maintenance, upgrades and reliability across long-running customer environments. *Career break 2010–2012, disclosed.*

Volunteer IT Assistant — Altec SA | Greece | Apr 2000 – Jun 2003

SELECTED ENGINEERING PROJECTS (ALL SELF-DIRECTED — NOT EMPLOYER SYSTEMS)

Written up with their limitations in github.com/sternnick: `homelab-infrastructure` and the project pages on my portfolio site.

Configuration management with CI gates — Ansible estate (5 roles, 7 playbooks, executable inventory, pinned tooling) with validation gates that hard-fail, plus runbooks, architecture decision records, a threat model and an incident postmortem.

Edge and DNS controls — tunnel-based remote access with the internal services kept private and only the edge exposed; expected-state assertions and a configuration-drift check for the edge; a DNS chain of forwarder → DNSSEC validator → encrypted upstream.

Self-hosted model serving — inference on own hardware with measured time-to-first-token, inter-token latency and cache occupancy used to make routing decisions, per-principal access control, and enforced ceilings on provider calls and agent fan-out.

CERTIFICATION & EDUCATION

AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Professional — issued Oct 2024, valid to Oct 2027

Technician for Computers, Networks and Communications (Informatics / Computer Networks & Support), Kavala, Greece

Languages: Greek (native) · English (professional working proficiency)